

Brute Syndicate

Volume 3

By: KD Emanuel

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Man, Let me tell you a Story.

A Short Story in fact.

-KD EMANUEL

Brian noticed that 13th street hadn't changed much in the last few years. Only some of the faces of the people roaming it were different. It was just as he remembered with dealers glaring at each other over their space and women lurking around showing off as much goods as they could. Nothing wrong with that though, especially for a 22-year-old young man. Right there in the center of it all was Tony. Tony hadn't changed much except for a few inches of height and like Kareem, broader shoulders, more tats and bigger muscles. But, it was still him, thinking he was a bad-ass.

Brian pulled up to Tony who glared at the car as if to say "who is this mutha-fucka?" He stood there decked out in some Gucci shoes which seem to be designed a little different from the ones Brian seen in magazines, Blue striped jeans, a red tucked in tank top and a long, gold chain with a cross hanging from it. Tony's jerry curl dripped like crazy, almost like he could have been a spokesman for whatever brand that had it drip like that and his hand looked like an Egyptian King, somewhat like Ramses draped in rings and bracelets. It was an obvious sign that Tony was cashing it in.

A smile lit up on the gangsta's face when he realized who the pair was in the car. "Stop playin!" Dawg, you home!"



Brian and Kareem jumped out of the car to greet Tony. As Tony and Kareem dapped each other up, Brian couldn't help but notice Tony whisper something into Kareem's ear. Then Kareem looked over at Brian and said, "Hey Streeter, I'll be right back. I got to say what's up to somebody."

Kareem took off across the street and Tony grabbed Brian by the shoulder, turning him back to face him. "Tell me, what's going on? What you down here for?"

Brian told him almost verbatim what he'd told Kareem less than an hour before. He was back looking for work to go back to school and finding it hard to land a job.

"I got ya, "Tony said as he reached in his pocket and pulled out a \$100 bill. "I know your broke ass gonna need this."

"I can't take this Th---"

"Enough Streeter. I don't care how long it's been since I've seen you. You my dawg and we take care of dawgs. Take it Streeter. It's hard out there for all of yall 9-5 Niggas. In a minute, I'll be pulling in so much I can put nine more of those fuckin' Franklins in your hand."



Brain reluctantly took the bill and slid it into his pocket. He pivoted and glared over Tony's shoulder at Kareem standing in the alley beside an abandoned house while saying. "Thanks T, I really---"

Kareem trotted across the street to join them. He nodded at Tony and said to Brian, "Hey Streeter, Ackerman wants to see you." "Ackerman? Well, I don't know if---" Tony put a hand on Streeter's shoulder. "Now you know you can't tell Ackerman no nigga. Just go over there and see what he want." Brian gave a glance to each of his friends and conceded, "Alright man, I'll see what he want."

Ackerman was an old school gangsta, which meant he was old enough to have run the streets when Brian's dad was around. In fact, whenever Brian was around, Ackerman wouldn't shut up about it. He seemed to be extremely proud that he knew his dad. Everyone was afraid of Ackerman but to Brian, the old man wasn't anything more than a local but big time drug dealer. He thought it was lame that Ackerman's conversation always started with some lame old shit about his dad.



Brian walked to the porch across the street where Ackerman was sitting. The man was about 6'4" and all of 300 pounds. He was always

dirty and Brian could see that in the years he'd been away, Ackerman had figured a way to become even more so. It's like he was living in the everglades, possibly eating and drinking gator meat and swamp water. He was the one who ran the neighborhood into its current state of the drug-infested ring. He's also the reason there were no real jobs possibly. The streets were lined with shady dealers and youthful kids waiting for their chance up to bat. He's also one of the main reasons Brian tried so hard to get out.

"Lil' Benny, what you doin 'back home? You done with school already?" He spoke through a thick and torn whiskey induced voice. A cancer stick dangled from the corner of his lips.

"Yes, sir. I'm just having a hard time finding a job. My aunt and uncle thought it would be good for me to come back, work and save up some money to go back for a higher degree."

Ackerman didn't smile but nodded his approval. "Well, I got a job if you want it. Chopping trees in the field for turpentine."

Brian thought about it, but he knew he couldn't think too long or else he'd insult his dad's old friend. But then again, he thought it was awful strange that Ackerman offered a legit job when there were so many others around. A man like Ackerman with so much money and power would have been as keen on tossing a bag of dope at Streeter to see how quick he could see it. Instead, he offered a legit job, although a hard one, but the pay was decent.

"Alright" Brian said, more out of desperation than appreciation. "I'll take it."

"Good boy. Be on 15th street over by your Uncle Spaz's place at 5:45 tomorrow morning."

Damn! Brian remembered the conversation with his aunt that morning about not wanting to wake up as early as his uncle did to go to work. He almost wished he'd pursue a job with his uncle as now, but he had the sneaking suspicion that no one worked for Ackerman in just the job he gave them. It felt as if someone indebted to Ackerman and wondered when he'd be called on to pay off that debt.

Ackerman looked down the street and muttered, "Alright Chief," which was his sign-off signaling the conversation was over. Ackerman stood up and walked away saying nothing more. Brian was numb as he stood on the steps. He had a job, which was great, but at what price? He turned and jogged back across the street. As he approached Kareem and Tony, he saw that they were talking to a couple of stoners. "Fellas, I need to run and pick my aunt up at work."

Kareem said, "I'm going to stay with T. Just hit us up when you trying to hang out."



“Cool. Ackerman has a job for me so I’ll see what I can do. Soon though.”

Brian hopped in his aunt’s car, happy to have seen his friends, but the hairs on the back of his neck raised in anticipation of getting out of there. College life had softened him from his street-hardened demeanor, and he could feel his old hangouts slowly pulling him back into the fray.

Brian arrived at the nursing home and waited for his aunt to finish her workday. He couldn't help but think about his eventful day. Had you asked him at the start how his day would go he sure wouldn't have thought he'd end up having a job and bumping into his old friends. Brian had the windows down on the brown two-door Chevy, listening to The Boss on the radio. Good old Springsteen was one of his favorites. Now, that was a man who knew what he wanted and didn't let anything stop him from getting it. He wanted to be like The Boss. He just had to make sure nothing got in his way either.

The excitement rose in Brian as it drew closer to time for his aunt to come out. He wanted to tell her about the job. Of course, it wasn't exactly what he'd thought of getting as a college graduate, but it was something and it was a start. Within ten minutes, his aunt was walking to the car and motioned with her finger for Brian to get into the passenger seat. She hated when anyone else drove. It just made her too nervous not being in control of the wheel. Brian obediently slid over without getting out of the car and before his Aunt could even ask, he was spitting off the events of the day. Unfortunately, his aunt wasn't as thrilled to hear about his experience that day he'd hoped, "What's wrong?" he asked.

"Streeter, I don't want you anywhere near Ackerman. You hear me? If you hang with him and his people you're asking for nothing but trouble." "You don't get it, Auntie. I thought it was bad idea too. But this is legit. He didn't even try to get me in on his bad stuff. I know what he does and what he's about. But, I need a job so I can get out of here and this is about the best paying job I'll find out here. Plus, I know it's a job I'll keep. There are no layoffs in turpentine."

Aunt Suzie dropped her head back against the headrest and turned slightly to glance, Brian couldn't help but feel the sudden jerkiness in her turns and braking. She was obviously upset about Ackerman.

"Listen, Streeter. I know you think maybe legit now, but it won't stay that way. This how Ackerman works. He gives you something you are not comfortable with. That's when he reminds you that he helped you when you had problems, tells you how good of a friend he was to you and how you don't owe him.... But, he makes it known that you really do. It's a cycle, Streeter, and Ackerman is very good at it. Don't' get involved with him. Nothing good will come of it.?"

She stopped talking, and Brian didn't respond. The drive home was uncomfortable and quiet. Brian knew she was right, even if he didn't want to acknowledge it. The car pulled along the front of the house.

"Streeter!" Yelled a familiar voice as Brian got out of his aunt's car. It was Tony pulling up in a gray Chevrolet.



“What up T?” Brian said, walking over to Tony’s side of the car.

As Brian walked away from his aunt’s car, she shook her head then dropped it and walked inside of the house. It was a long workday, and she was just too tired to argue.

“A lot been goin’ on, my Nigga.

“I got some foxes that want to hang out with us tonight. You in?” Tony said, throwing his thumb towards the back of his car in a hitchhiking motion.

Brian glanced at Tony to make eye contact with him while the thought of some ladies was definitely a good move. “You should come and chill with us, I just got to pick up Kareem so you going to have to get in the back said with a mischievous smirk on his face while he rolled a joint on his lap on top of magazine.

Brian could hardly keep his eyes off the dope for he was itching for a chance to get high from all the stress and plus celebrating for having a gig now. He hated himself for what he was about to say, but he said it anyway, “Nah can’t do it tonight, I have to work tomorrow. I’m gonna pass on this one tonight.”

Tony smiled, “You got a job already, Nigga? Give me my hundred back!” He had a smile on his face. Tony had seemingly forgot that Ackerman had offered Brian a job earlier.

Brian told Tony, “Yeah, I’ll be working in the turpentine fields for Ackerman.”

“Oh, he got you doing back breaking work. I can dig it though,” Tony commented. “Well, get up with us tomorrow when you get off. We’ll be around.”

Brian slapped his hand on the top of the car twice in a farewell as Tony sped off.

Brian had just finished brushing his teeth and was climbing into bed when his uncle came in the room. “I talked to your aunt after work today. She’s worried, Streeter.”

“Yeah, well she doesn’t need to. I can handle it.”

“I know you think you can but we worked hard to keep you out of a lot of these problems.”

There was a lengthy silence between the two of them. Then, at the same time, they tried to speak. Brian conceded to his uncle who said, “Look son, remember what you came here for. Just work to get your goal and don’t let Ackerman put anything in your head that will lead to the destruction of it all.”

Brian sat and listened, but he kept repeating in his mind ‘Ackerman ain’t that bad. Why is everyone so damn worried?’ He continued nodding to his uncle and then answered, “I’ll be careful. I promise.”

Uncle Spaz patted Brian on the shoulder.

“We just care about you, Brian. We want you to do well and make your parents proud. That’s all.”

“I know it.”

Uncle Spaz walked to the door, flipped off the light and said before leaving the room, “Get some sleep then. Those fields can be rough work.”

ON TO VOLUME 2